DTU CONSULTING GROUP

PLAYBOOK

Consulting Pitch Deck Playbook

What makes a consulting pitch deck win, and how to build one step by step, tailored to a student consulting group pitching startup founders.

Student-run consulting group | Startup clients | Market entry · GTM · Research & sizing · Ops | Presented live + sent as leave-behind

Who this is for and how to read it

This playbook is built for a student-run consulting group pitching startup founders on market entry, GTM/marketing strategy, research and market sizing, and ops work, with the deck presented live and then sent as a leave-behind. You did not name a biggest weakness, so the rubric in section 8 doubles as a diagnostic: score your last two decks before reading the rest. You did not give a budget either; I assume fees are low or pro bono, which changes how pricing and credibility work (sections 5 and the closing critique).

The single idea that shapes everything below: a founder is not buying a firm brand from you. They are buying evidence that a few students will save them founder-hours and produce something they can act on. Every slide either proves that or wastes their time.

Every claim carries one of three labels:

- **Evidence**: backed by research, buyer surveys or a published framework.
- **Practitioner consensus**: repeated by many experienced consultants; plausible but not tested.
- **My call**: my opinionated judgment for your context where sources disagree.

One limit up front: Reddit, LinkedIn and YouTube transcripts were not readable from here, so community and video views are under-represented. Details are under Sources at the end.

1. The 10 principles that separate winning decks

Winning decks teach the founder something, prove you understood their problem, and make yes the easy answer; forgettable decks describe your club. The strongest buyer evidence comes from RAIN Group's study of 700+ B2B purchases and Hinge's 2020 survey of 362 consulting buyers; most slide-craft rules are practitioner consensus, not tested science.

#	Principle	Why it wins	Evidence level	Source
1	Diagnose before you deck	The deal is decided in the discovery call; the deck should confirm a problem the founder already named, not introduce it	Practitioner consensus	Consulting Success
2	Teach them one thing they didn't know	Bringing new ideas was the #1 factor separating winners from runners-up in buyer interviews	Evidence	RAIN Group
3	Play their problem back in their words	Winners showed they understood buyer needs about 2.5x as often as runners-up; consultants routinely misjudge clients' top challenges	Evidence	RAIN via RadioInfo, Hinge
4	Lead with the answer	A busy reader gets your recommendation in the first minute and reads everything else as support	Framework (Minto)	StrategyCase
5	Titles that tell the story on their own	Read only the slide titles top to bottom; if they don't form an argument, the deck has none	Practitioner consensus	Storytelling with Data
6	One message per slide, readable in 3 seconds	Extra material competes with your point; Duarte's Glance Test targets about 3 seconds per slide	Consensus, partly backed by learning research	Duarte

#	Principle	Why it wins	Evidence level	Source
7	Two artifacts: a presented deck and a leave-behind	Reading dense text while listening hurts comprehension, and a sparse projected deck fails when read alone	Evidence (learning lab studies)	Mayer et al. 2001, Duarte
8	The team is the product	Team skills were the top deciding factor for almost half of consulting buyers	Evidence	Hinge
9	Shrink the perceived risk	Winners made the return case and lowered the buyer's sense of risk more than runners-up	Evidence	RAIN Group
10	Make yes easy: options and a dated next step	Offering choices moves the question from whether to hire you to which version; proposals without a next step tend to stall	Practitioner consensus	Alan Weiss, Agiled

My call For a student group, principles 2, 3 and 8 carry most of the weight. A founder will forgive plain design; they will not forgive a deck that could have been sent to any startup.

2. The slide-by-slide skeleton for your context

Build 12 main slides you can present in 15 to 20 minutes, plus an appendix; the founder's problem fills slides 2 to 6 before your club appears at all. Every example below uses one invented client so the titles connect: **MediStock**, a seed-stage startup selling inventory software to independent pharmacies, which wants to enter a second city.

#	Slide	Purpose	Key message	Example action title
1	Title	Signal this was built for them	Their goal, your offer, a time frame	Getting MediStock its first 50 pharmacies in Pune: a 6-week entry sprint
2	Executive summary	Give the whole answer in one slide (SCQA)	What you recommend testing and what they get	We propose a 6-week sprint that picks Pune's best entry segment and hands you a tested sales script

#	Slide	Purpose	Key message	Example action title
3	What we heard	Prove you listened; use their words	Their problem, restated with their numbers	Founder-led sales won 40 pharmacies in your home city, but it cannot be copied into a new one
4	Why now	Make inaction feel costly	The cost of waiting, in their metrics	Every quarter without a second city weakens the growth story for your next raise
5	Starting hypotheses	Show you already think like their team	2 to 3 testable bets, each with how you'd test it	We believe chain-adjacent pharmacies, not standalone shops, are the fastest way in
6	One outside-in insight	Teach them something (principle 2)	A finding from public data they likely haven't seen	Pune has fewer pharmacy-software competitors per 1,000 outlets than your home city
7	Approach	Show a path, not a menu of activities	3 phases, each ending in a decision	Three 2-week phases, each ending with a go/no-go you make, not us
8	Deliverables and scope	Kill ambiguity early	What they get, what is excluded	You'll get four things you can use the week we finish, and here is what we won't do
9	Team	Make the people the product	Who does what, plus who checks the work	Four analysts with SaaS sales research experience, reviewed weekly by an alumni advisor
10	Proof	Lower the risk of hiring students	Past outcome or a sample of your work	Our last startup client used our pricing analysis in their seed deck
11	Options	Turn whether into which	2 to 3 scoped options, one recommended	Three ways to work together; we recommend the 6-week sprint

#	Slide	Purpose	Key message	Example action title
12	Next steps	Make yes a calendar action	A dated first step and what you need from them	Say yes by the 15th and you'll have the Pune playbook before your board meeting
A	Appendix	Hold detail for the leave-behind	Method, bios, sample output, sources, risks	(Topic titles are fine here)

Adjust slides 5 and 6 by engagement type My call:

Engagement	Hypothesis slide shows	Outside-in exhibit to bring
Market entry	Which segment or city to enter first, and why	Competitor density or demand proxy by segment
GTM / marketing	Which 2 channels to test, with cost per lead guesses	Teardown of 3 competitors' funnels or ads
Research and sizing	Your top-down vs bottom-up sizing logic	A rough market size with assumptions shown
Ops / org	Where the bottleneck probably is	Process map from what they told you, with the suspected choke point marked

On length, sources disagree. Agency templates suggest 12 to 20 slides (SlideGenius); proposal coaches push 3 to 5 pages (Agiled). DocSend's fundraising data found 65% of unsuccessful pre-seed teams had longer-than-average decks (TechCrunch). That is investor data, not consulting-buyer data, but founders read decks the way investors read theirs: fast. My call 12 main slides, hard cap; everything else goes to the appendix.

3. Storytelling and structure: SCQA plus the pyramid

Use SCQA to open (slides 1 to 4) and the Pyramid Principle to organize everything after it: one governing thought, three reasons, evidence under each. Minto's core discipline is to think bottom-up but communicate top-down (RoadToOffer summarizing Minto). Duarte adds the emotional engine: persuasive talks move back and forth between what is today and what could be (Tomasz Tunguz on Resonate).

Worked example: MediStock's opening, in four sentences

Element	What it does	MediStock version
Situation	States facts the founder already agrees with	You've won 40 pharmacies in your home city, almost all through your own sales calls
Complication	Names the tension that forces a decision	Your next raise needs a second city, and you can't personally sell in Pune
Question	The question your proposal answers	Which Pune segment should you target first, and what sales motion wins it within 90 days?
Answer	Your recommendation, stated plainly	Start with chain-adjacent pharmacies via distributor referrals; we'll prove or kill that in 6 weeks and hand you the playbook

Answer first or complication first? Minto's default is answer first, but she allows the order to flex. My call Live, spend 60 seconds on situation and complication in the founder's own words so they nod twice, then give the answer. In the leave-behind, put the answer at the top of slide 2, because a reader skimming on a phone may never reach slide 4.



MediStock pitch pyramid: one governing thought, three key lines, twelve slides. If a slide can’t be placed under one of the three columns, it belongs in the appendix.

Build it in five steps

1. Write the governing thought as one sentence a founder could repeat to a co-founder: what you'll do, by when, and what they get.
2. Ask "why should I believe that?" three times. Your answers become the three key lines; check they don't overlap and nothing important is missing.
3. List the slides that prove each key line. If a slide supports none of them, cut it or move it to the appendix.
4. Build a ghost deck: titles only, one rough sketch per slide, no design. Read the titles top to bottom; they should tell the whole story (Storytelling with Data on horizontal logic).
5. Hand the title list to someone outside the team. If they can't tell you what you're proposing in 30 seconds, rewrite the titles before touching visuals.

Where Duarte's contrast fits My call: slides 3 and 4 are "what is" (the stuck founder), slides 5 to 8 are "what could be" (the playbook in hand), and slide 12 asks for the step that connects them.

4. Visual and design rules

Design has one job: make each slide's title obviously true at a glance. Restraint reads as competence; a student deck that looks like an agency template invites the question of who did the thinking.

Element	Rule	Why / source
Layout	Same grid on every slide: title in the same spot, one exhibit below it, an optional one-line takeaway at the bottom	Titles that jump around break the flip-through read (Deckary) Consensus
Titles	Full sentence, the claim not the topic, 2 lines max	The title carries the argument; the body proves it (Analyst Academy) Consensus
Charts	Pick the chart from the message: bars to compare, lines for trends, waterfalls for bridges, stacked bars for composition	Wrong chart type hides the point; Mekko and waterfall earn their place only when the message needs two dimensions or a bridge (Analyst Academy) Consensus
Chart labels	Label data directly, drop legends, grey everything except the one bar or line that proves the title	Legends force eye travel; one highlight directs attention (Analyst Academy) Consensus
Decoration	No 3D, gradients, shadows or clip art; every mark should carry data	Tufte's data-ink argument against chartjunk (Wikipedia summary) Framework

Element	Rule	Why / source
Sources	A source line under every number, footnotes for assumptions	Consulting exhibits carry extensive sourcing to back claims to executives (Analyst Academy) Consensus
Fonts	One sans-serif family, three sizes (title, body, footnote)	Mixing three or four typefaces reads as chaos (Climb the Ladder summarizing Duarte) Consensus
Font size, live	Body text 24 pt or larger; Kawasaki argues for a 30 pt floor	A big floor forces you to cut words (HubSpot on Kawasaki's 10/20/30) Opinion; my call is 24
Colour	Two or three colours plus grey; reserve one accent for "this is the point"	Colour that means nothing becomes noise (Climb the Ladder) Consensus
Contrast	Text contrast of at least 4.5:1 (3:1 for large text); never encode meaning in red vs green alone	Projectors and phone screens wash out light greys (WCAG via Rocket Validator) Standard
Images	Screenshots of the client's product, a competitor's ad, a real pharmacy shelf; never stock handshakes	Real artefacts prove you did homework; stock photos prove you didn't My call

Text density: the main disagreement. Tufte argues slides are too sparse and that slideware averages far fewer data points per graphic than print (HN discussion of Tufte's PowerPoint essay). Duarte and Kawasaki argue a projected slide should be grasped in about 3 seconds. Mayer's lab studies found that adding on-screen text that duplicates narration reduced learning (Mayer, Heiser and Lonn 2001), though those were students learning science, not founders judging a pitch.

My call Both camps are right about different artefacts. Projected slides: title plus one exhibit, roughly 30 body words or fewer. Leave-behind: same titles and exhibits, plus two or three full sentences of explanation per slide, so it stands alone without you.

Avoid outright: slide transitions and animations, logos of every tool you used, "Thank you / Questions?" as the final slide (use next steps instead), slides without page numbers (founders reference "slide 7" in replies), and AI-generated illustrations that look generic.

5. Content that builds trust

A student group's credibility gap is not intelligence; it is reliability. Founders worry you will disappear at exam time, deliver a generic report, or eat their week with questions.

Each trust element below answers one of those fears.

Element	What to show	If your club has no track record yet
Case study	Client type, problem, what you did, what the client did with it afterwards, one-line quote	Show an excerpt of real work: a case-competition deck, a sizing model, a teardown you did for practice. Label it honestly
Starting hypotheses	2 to 3 testable bets, each with the data that would prove or kill it	This is where new teams can outshine experienced ones; it costs only thinking
Outside-in exhibit	One finding from public data the founder probably hasn't assembled	Same; 4 to 6 hours of desk research usually produces one
Team	Each person's role on this project, one relevant proof point, hours per week, who reviews the work	Name a faculty member or alumni advisor who signs off each deliverable
Scope and options	In scope, out of scope, 2 to 3 options, the founder's time commitment	Even pro bono, show the founder's "investment" in hours and data access
Risks	The 2 or 3 things most likely to go wrong and your plan for each	Exam weeks and team turnover belong here, with a named backup person

Why generic proof fails. In DemandGen's 2024 survey, 51% of B2B buyers said vendor content was too generic for their needs, up from 38% the year before (DemandGen Report). A case study only works if the founder sees their own situation in it. One closely matched example beats five loosely related ones.

Hypotheses vs giving away the work. Blair Enns argues firms should stop handing over their thinking for free in pitches (Win Without Pitching, via a practitioner review). My call Give away the questions, not the answers: show what you'd test and how, not the finished recommendation. A founder who sees sharp questions wants to know the answers, which is the engagement.

Outside-in sources that work for startups My call: competitors' pricing pages and changelogs, their job postings (which reveal priorities), app-store and Google reviews, outlet or store counts from map listings, and government or industry-body statistics. Cite every one.

Team slide. In Hinge's 2020 consulting-buyer study, team skills were the top deciding factor for almost half of buyers (Hinge). Replace "3rd-year BBA, President of Finance Club" with what that person will do on this project and why they're suited to it.

Scope, time and pro bono. Taproot, drawing on 1,500+ pro bono projects, says to treat a pro bono client exactly like a paying one: the budget is people's time, the main failure modes are scope creep and team turnover, and much finished pro bono work is never implemented (Taproot, week 1, week 2). So your options slide must state what the founder gives (for example, a kickoff plus one hour a week, as university programs like Practera ask) and list what you will not do.

Options, and where price goes. Weiss recommends three options that rise in value, so the client chooses which rather than whether (Alan Weiss); his options are meant to add value, not just more hours (Weiss on options). Sources split on placement: some trainers hold price until the recommendation is accepted (CustomerThink), others put tiered prices in the proposal itself (Agiled). My call Put options on slide 11, after the proof and before next steps. Founders expect to see the price and resent hunting for it. I found no reliable data on what student groups charge, so I can't benchmark your fee level; a small fee or refundable deposit may signal seriousness, but that is my opinion, not evidence.

6. Delivery: live, sent cold, and Q&A

Present live whenever you can, then send the leave-behind within 24 hours. Consulting Success argues presenting live is one of the cheapest, highest-impact changes to close rates, because an emailed proposal competes with everything else in the inbox (Consulting Success, 2026)

Practitioner consensus; their close-rate figures are coaching anecdotes, not audited data.

Live: a 30-minute meeting plan My call

1. Minutes 0 to 3: confirm what you heard. Ask, "Is this still the problem?" If they correct you, the correction is gold; adjust live.
2. Minutes 3 to 18: slides 2 to 11. Invite interruptions; a founder asking questions on slide 5 is buying.
3. Minutes 18 to 27: Q&A.
4. Minutes 27 to 30: next steps (slide 12). Pitch coach Nathan Gold advises never ending on Q&A; close with a prepared final remark instead (Silicon Prairie News).

Bring three people at most: one lead presenter, one person who owns the numbers, one note-taker who also watches the founder's reactions. Do not read slides aloud; if the slide says it, say something else.

Sent cold or as a leave-behind

- Assume a fast skim. DocSend data on investor decks put average review time at about 2 minutes 12 seconds in 2023 (TechCrunch), and one tracker's analysis of 3,000 decks found the first page gets more than twice the time of any later page (Papermark via Presentations.ai). That is fundraising data, so treat it as directional.
- So slide 2 must carry the whole pitch, and every title must stand alone.
- Email body: three lines (their problem in a sentence, what you propose, one dated ask) plus the PDF named like `MediStock_Pune-entry-proposal_ClubName.pdf`.
- Follow up a few days after sending with a specific note about their problem, not "just checking in" (Agiled).

Q&A preparation

List 15 to 20 likely questions, sort them into answer now, need data, and take offline, and rehearse a two-to-three-sentence short answer for each. Then run a "murder board": a senior member or alumnus plays the most skeptical founder they can. Answer short first, then bridge back to your key message; if you don't know, say so and commit to a date (Buckley School guide).

Question founders ask student teams	Strong answer pattern
Why should I trust students with this?	Name the reviewer, show a work sample, offer a checkpoint at week 2 where they can stop
What happens during your exams?	Give the calendar, the backup person and the dates you won't be available
How much of my time will this take?	A number: kickoff plus 1 hour a week, and which data you need by when
What if your hypothesis is wrong?	That's the point of testing; show what you'd recommend if it fails
Who sees my data?	Offer an NDA, name who has access, say what you will and won't publish
Can you also look at X?	Yes, as a phase 2 or swap; never a silent add-on
Why not just hire an intern?	An intern needs managing; you deliver a decision-ready output with your own QA

7. 15 common mistakes, ranked

No study ranks pitch mistakes by how many deals they cost, so this order is **My call**, weighted by the buyer evidence in section 1: anything that signals "this team doesn't

get my business" ranks above anything cosmetic. The top five lose the deal on their own; the bottom five rarely lose it alone but compound the rest.

Rank	Mistake	Why it loses	Fix
1	A generic deck that could go to any startup	Buyers increasingly reject generic content; winners show they understood the need (DemandGen, RAIN)	Put three facts only this founder told you on slides 2 to 4
2	Pitching before diagnosing	The founder hasn't named the cost of the problem, so nothing feels urgent (Consulting Success)	Ask in discovery: what does staying stuck cost you per month?
3	No insight, only a list of services	Teaching something new is the top winner behaviour (RAIN)	One outside-in exhibit on slide 6
4	Opening with "About us"	The founder cares about their problem first (Agiled)	Move the club to slides 9 and 10
5	The reliability fear left unanswered	Team quality is the top deciding factor for many buyers (Hinge)	Name the reviewer, the backup person and a week-2 checkpoint
6	Vague deliverables ("a market research report")	The founder can't picture using it; scope creep follows (Taproot)	Name each deliverable by the decision it supports, plus an out-of-scope list
7	Hidden cost of founder time	Pro bono still costs them hours, and they know it (Taproot)	State hours per week and data needed
8	No dated next step	Proposals ending in "let me know" stall (Agiled)	End with one dated action
9	Overpromising outcomes	Inflated claims raise perceived risk instead of lowering it (RAIN)	Promise decisions and artefacts you control, not revenue you don't
10	Wrong or unsourced numbers about their business	One wrong fact about their company undoes ten right ones **My call**	Source every number; have the founder's own figures checked by two people

Rank	Mistake	Why it loses	Fix
11	Topic titles ("Market Overview")	The deck has no argument when skimmed (Storytelling with Data)	Ghost deck first; every title a sentence
12	One take-it-or-leave-it option	A single price invites a yes-or-no (Weiss)	Two or three options with a recommended one
13	Text walls read aloud	Duplicated on-screen text and speech hurt comprehension (Mayer et al.)	Sparse presented deck, denser leave-behind
14	Too many slides	Longer decks correlated with unsuccessful raises in DocSend's data (TechCrunch)	12-slide cap; appendix for the rest
15	Team contradicts itself in Q&A	Visible disagreement reads as disorganisation My call	Murder-board rehearsal; assign an owner for each question type

8. Pre-send checklist and scoring rubric

Run the checklist on every deck; use the rubric on your last two decks now to find your real weakness, then on each new deck before it goes out. Thresholds are My call.

Pre-send checklist 0 of 17 done

- [ ] Slide 2 states the recommendation, the time frame and what the founder gets
- [ ] Slides 2 to 4 contain at least three facts or phrases only this founder gave you
- [ ] Read titles only, top to bottom: they tell the whole story
- [ ] Every slide has one message; nothing on it fails to support the title
- [ ] At least one exhibit teaches the founder something from outside-in data
- [ ] Every number has a source line; the founder's own figures are double-checked
- [ ] Deliverables are named by the decision they support; an out-of-scope list exists
- [ ] Founder time commitment is stated in hours
- [ ] Team slide shows role, relevant proof, hours per week and the reviewer

- [ ] Exam dates and backup person are covered
- [ ] Two or three options, one marked as recommended
- [ ] Final slide is a dated next step, not "Thank you"
- [ ] Main deck is 12 slides or fewer; detail is in the appendix
- [ ] Leave-behind version reads without a presenter
- [ ] Text contrast and font sizes pass on a phone screen and a projector
- [ ] File name, page numbers, client name spelled right on every slide
- [ ] Murder-board rehearsal done; question owners assigned

Scoring rubric (0 to 5 per dimension, 45 points total)

Dimension	0 =	3 =	5 =	Your score
Client understanding	Could be sent to any startup	Mentions their company and goal	Restates their problem, numbers and words; founder would say "exactly"	–
Insight	Describes your services	Applies a standard framework to their case	Shows something new from outside-in data	–
Storyline	Topic titles, no clear ask	Answer appears but late or blurry	Answer on slide 2; titles alone tell the story	–
Evidence	Unsourced claims	Most numbers sourced	Every number sourced; assumptions explicit	–
Slide clarity	Text walls, decoration	Mostly one point per slide	Each slide passes a 3-second glance	–
Credibility	Club bio and logos	Relevant team, a past example	Named reviewer, matched proof, reliability plan	–

Dimension	0 =	3 =	5 =	Your score
Scope and options	One vague offer	Deliverables listed	Decision-linked deliverables, out of scope, 2 to 3 options	–
Call to action	"Questions?"	Generic next step	Dated, specific, easy first step	–
Delivery readiness	Not rehearsed	Rehearsed once	Murder-boarded, Q&A owners set, leave-behind ready	–

– / 45 **Score each dimension to see a verdict.**

How to read your score: below 25, rebuild from the ghost deck; 25 to 35, fix your two lowest dimensions before sending; 36 or above, send it. Any dimension at 0 or 1 blocks sending regardless of total.

9. Templates

Copy the executive summary below into slide 2 and fill every bracket; if you can't fill one, that's a gap in your discovery, not your writing.

Fill-in-the-blank executive summary slide

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TITLE (one sentence, max 2 lines):
[Client] can [specific goal] by [date] if it [key move];
we propose a [N]-week [engagement type] to get there.

Where you are      [Situation in the founder's words, with one of their numbers]
What's in the way  [Complication] - waiting costs you [cost in their metric]
Our starting view  [Hypothesis / answer in one sentence]
How we'll prove it [Phase 1] -> [Phase 2] -> [Phase 3], each ending in a go/no-go you make
What you get       [Deliverable 1, named by the decision it supports]
                   [Deliverable 2]  [Deliverable 3]
What it takes      [X] founder hours/week · [data you need] · [option / fee]
Next step          [One dated action, e.g. "30-min kickoff on 14 Nov"]

Source line: [where each number came from]
```

10 sample action titles (MediStock and other invented startups)

Topic title (weak)	Action title (strong)	Engagement
Market overview	Pune's 4,000 independent pharmacies are half as served by inventory software as your home city	Market entry
Entry options	Entering through distributors reaches 3x more pharmacies in 90 days than direct sales, at lower cost	Market entry
Customer segments	Chain-adjacent pharmacies buy fastest because they already track stock digitally	GTM
Channel analysis	WhatsApp referrals produced most of your current customers; paid search produced almost none	GTM
Competitor review	Your two largest competitors both lead on price, leaving onboarding speed undefended	GTM / marketing
Market size	The reachable market is about one-fifth of the headline figure once you exclude outlets without a computer	Research and sizing
Survey results	Pharmacists rank stock-outs above price as their top pain, which supports your premium tier	Research
Process review	Order approval takes 3 days because every order waits for the founder's sign-off	Ops
Team structure	Moving refunds to support would free about 6 founder hours a week	Ops
Next steps	A yes by the 15th gets you the playbook before your board meeting	Any

Every number above is illustrative. In a real deck each one needs a source line, and those about the client must come from the client.

10. Reading and watching list

If your team reads only three, make it RAIN (what buyers reward), Taproot (how pro bono work fails) and the Analyst Academy breakdown (how good exhibits are built). The rest deepen one skill each.

#	Source	Type	Good for
1	RAIN Group, What Sales Winners Do Differently (2013, updated 2023)	Buyer research, 700+ purchases	The best evidence on what makes a buyer pick one seller over the runner-up; see the top-10 factor list
2	Hinge, Inside the Buyer's Brain: Consulting Edition (2020)	Buyer and seller survey, 362 + 369	Where consultants misjudge what clients care about
3	Taproot, Six Weeks to Become a Pro Bono Manager (2012)	Practitioner guide, 1,500+ projects	Scoping, client readiness and implementation for unpaid work: your exact situation
4	Barbara Minto, *The Pyramid Principle* (summary)	Classic framework	Answer-first structure and SCQA; read the book, not just summaries
5	Analyst Academy, How McKinsey creates clear charts (2021; also a YouTube video)	Teardown	Chart choice, action titles on exhibits, highlighting and sourcing; it dissects a McKinsey report on India
6	Nancy Duarte: The Glance Test, slides vs slidedocs, *Resonate*	Framework and tools	Slide clarity, and building a separate leave-behind
7	Storytelling with Data, horizontal logic	Short practitioner post	The titles-only test in five minutes
8	Consulting Success, Your discovery decides the deal (2026)	Practitioner article	Discovery questions that make the founder name the cost of the problem
9	Alan Weiss, *Value-Based Fees* and option design	Practitioner books and blog	Structuring options so they add value, not just hours
10	Edward Tufte, *The Cognitive Style of PowerPoint* (discussion)	Classic critique	The strongest counterargument to sparse slides; keeps your leave-behind honest

Honourable mention for the counter-view: Blair Enns's *Win Without Pitching Manifesto* (review), which argues against free pitching altogether.

11. Where this advice breaks

Most of the evidence here comes from paid B2B purchases, investor decks and Western consulting buyers. A founder deciding whether to accept low-cost help from students is a different buyer, so treat every rule above as a strong default, not a law.

Situations where the conventions fail

Situation	What breaks	Do this instead
Founder hates decks or wants a conversation	A 12-slide walkthrough feels like theatre	Bring a one-page brief and a whiteboard; keep the deck as a leave-behind only
Accelerator, incubator or university program with its own form	Your structure fights theirs and looks like you didn't read it	Follow their template exactly; put your insight inside their headings (Agiled)
Warm referral or repeat client who has already said yes	A heavy proposal adds friction to a decided deal (Agiled)	Send a short scope note and a start date
Very early or non-corporate founder (family business, social enterprise)	Consulting jargon and answer-first certainty can read as arrogant	Plain language, their vocabulary, a question-first opening; ask before you assert
Pure research or sizing work	There is no honest answer to put first	Lead with the decision the research will unlock and your method; don't fake a conclusion
A founder who wants to co-create	Arriving with the answer leaves nothing to build together; RAIN ranks "collaborated with me" second among winner behaviours (RadioInfo on RAIN)	Present hypotheses as options and let them pick which to test first
Founders keep taking your hypotheses and going quiet	You are giving the work away (Win Without Pitching)	Share the questions and the test plan, not the findings

Top 5 ways your group could follow this guide and still lose

1. **You pitched the wrong founder or the wrong problem.** Taproot names fit and readiness as the first obstacle: if the project isn't a top priority or the founder has no bandwidth, even a perfect deck produces nothing (Taproot). Qualify before you build: is this in their top three problems, and will they give you an hour a week?
2. **Your real competitor is the founder plus an AI tool on a Sunday afternoon.** My call Desk research and frameworks are now cheap. Win by offering what they can't do alone: 30 customer calls, field visits, a tested script. Put that labour on the approach slide.
3. **The deck follows every rule and still feels templated.** Mechanical use of this guide produces exactly the generic content buyers complain about (DemandGen). If you removed the client's name, would the deck still make sense? Then rewrite it.
4. **You promised more than a student team can deliver.** Scope creep and team turnover are the main reasons pro bono projects slip (Taproot), and founders talk to each other. A smaller scope delivered on time wins the next three clients.
5. **You were slow.** Proposals that arrive after the founder's enthusiasm fades get ghosted more often (Agiled). Student calendars make this the most likely failure of all. My call Send the deck within 48 hours of the discovery call, even if it's 80% polished.

Sources

What I could and couldn't read. Searches restricted to Reddit and LinkedIn returned no pages from either site, so no Reddit, LinkedIn or Quora content informs this guide and none is quoted. A YouTube page fetch was rate-limited, so I read no video transcripts; the one video referenced is used through its companion article. Hacker News and one Substack review were readable. Community and video perspectives are therefore under-represented; the buyer-side view rests on surveys (RAIN, Hinge, DemandGen) rather than buyer threads.

Opened and read in full

- RAIN Group: Sales Research, What Sales Winners Do Differently
- RadioInfo Asia: What Buyers Say About Sales People (summary of RAIN's top-10 factors)
- Hinge: New Research, Consulting Buyer Criteria and Priorities
- DemandGen Report: 2024 Content Preferences Benchmark Survey
- TechCrunch: That 30-slide deck won't cut it anymore
- Consulting Success: Your Discovery Decides The Deal
- Agiled: How to Write a Consulting Proposal That Closes
- Analyst Academy: How McKinsey creates clear and insightful charts
- Taproot: Six Weeks to Become a Pro Bono Manager, Week Two

Cited from search-result excerpts (not opened in full; used for non-numeric claims or clearly labelled secondary figures)

- Taproot, Week One
- StrategyCase: The Pyramid Principle
- RoadToOffer: SCQA Framework
- Tomasz Tunguz on Duarte's Resonate
- Duarte: The Glance Test
- Duarte: The slides you deliver vs the slidedoc you leave behind
- Storytelling with Data: Horizontal logic
- Mayer, Heiser and Lonn (2001), Cognitive constraints on multimedia learning
- Wikipedia: Edward Tufte
- Hacker News: Edward Tufte, Information Sage
- Deckary: Consulting slide standards
- Climb the Ladder: How to design a presentation that actually works
- HubSpot: Kawasaki's 10/20/30 rule
- Rocket Validator: WCAG contrast checker
- Alan Weiss: Monday Morning Memo
- Alan Weiss: How to create dramatic options
- CustomerThink: Never present price to an unsold buyer
- Agiled: Why clients ghost after a proposal
- SlideGenius: Key elements of a consulting services pitch deck
- Presentations.ai: Pitch deck statistics (secondary compilation of DocSend and Papermark data)
- Silicon Prairie News: Q&A with pitch coach Nathan Gold
- Buckley School: Presentation questions, how ready are you?
- Mick Mel: The Win Without Pitching Manifesto (review)
- Practera: ScaleUp Startup program

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Labels: **Evidence** research-backed · **Consensus** practitioner consensus · **Framework** published framework or standard · **My call** judgment for your context. All MediStock examples are invented.